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CAPITAL ADVISORY

INVESTOR GUIDE

How Family Offices Evaluate Opportunities

What family offices weigh beyond headline returns: alignment, governance, liquidity, and relationship quality.

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Family offices evaluate opportunities through a lens that differs materially from institutional fund managers. Return potential matters, but so do alignment with the family's values, governance rights, liquidity expectations, and the quality of the relationship with sponsors and management teams. Understanding how that lens works, and how it differs from the fund playbook most founders have been coached against, is the difference between a process that builds momentum and one that stalls politely.

The differences begin with structure. A fund manager answers to limited partners on a defined fund life, which disciplines everything from check size to exit timing. A family office answers to a family, which means the mandate can be broader, the hold period longer, and the decision process both faster and more personal. Capital that is not forced to exit is capital that underwrites differently, and founders who present to a family office as if it were a growth fund routinely answer the wrong questions well.

KEY FINDINGS

- 01 Family offices weigh alignment, governance rights, and liquidity as heavily as return potential.
 - 02 Concise, institutional-quality materials and direct access to decision-makers move processes forward.
 - 03 A credible equity story with transparent risk disclosure consistently outperforms polished marketing.
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SECTION 01 OF 03

Investment Criteria

Most family offices begin with sector and stage fit, then assess the durability of cash flows, downside protection, and the credibility of the capital strategy. Direct investments often receive more scrutiny on management quality and governance than fund commitments, because the family cannot diversify a direct position the way a fund diversifies a portfolio. A single direct investment carries the family's name alongside its capital, and the diligence reflects that weight.

Downside protection deserves particular attention in preparation. Where a growth fund models the distribution of outcomes and accepts that some positions go to zero, many family offices underwrite closer to the way a credit committee does: what is the realistic worst case, what does the business look like in that case, and how does the structure protect the position. Founders who arrive with preference math, covenant thinking, and honest downside scenarios already modeled signal that they understand their counterparty.

Sector affinity also runs deeper than a screening filter. Many family offices concentrate where the family built its operating wealth, and in those sectors they bring pattern recognition that rivals any specialist fund. Pitching a logistics-fortune family office on a supply-chain business means presenting to people who may know the working-capital rhythms of the industry better than the founder does. That depth cuts both ways: credibility compounds quickly, and embellishment is detected just as quickly.

SECTION 02 OF 03

Process Dynamics

Family offices typically move deliberately. They favor concise, institutional-quality materials, clear use of proceeds, and direct access to decision-makers. A fragmented process with multiple handoffs often signals misalignment before terms are even discussed. The founder who insists on routing every exchange through advisors, or who cannot answer capital-structure questions without a banker present, raises a quiet flag that no deck can lower.

Deliberate does not mean slow, and this is the most common misreading of family office behavior. When conviction forms, a principal-led office can move from first meeting to term sheet faster than any investment committee, because the decision may sit with two or three people who talk to each other daily. The deliberateness sits earlier in the process: the months of relationship-building, the unhurried second and third conversations, the preference for watching a management team operate across quarters rather than across a data room.

Founders should plan for that rhythm rather than fight it. The practical implication is to open family office conversations six to twelve months before capital is needed, share updates in the interim that demonstrate execution against stated plans, and treat every interaction as diligence, because it is. An update that quietly walks back a projection made three months earlier does more damage in a family office process than in a fund process, where personnel and attention turn over faster.

SECTION 03 OF 03

What Differentiates Winners

The best-received opportunities combine a credible equity story, transparent risk disclosure, and a capital structure that leaves room for strategic optionality. Founders who can articulate unit economics and capital priorities without relying on slides alone consistently outperform in family office processes, because unscripted fluency is read as evidence that the numbers live in the operator rather than in the deck.

Transparency on risk carries unusual weight with this investor class. A family office that has operated businesses through cycles has seen every category of corporate distress, and a founder who names the two or three things that could genuinely impair the business, alongside what is being done about them, builds more conviction than one who presents an unblemished story. Omission reads as either inexperience or evasion, and neither supports a long-hold relationship.

Finally, alignment is examined in both directions. The family is deciding whether the founder is someone they want to be partners with for a decade; the founder should be conducting the same evaluation. Asking about the office's decision process, prior direct investments, behavior in downside scenarios, and expectations around information rights is not impertinence, it is exactly the seriousness the best family offices are looking for across the table.

NEXT STEP

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